



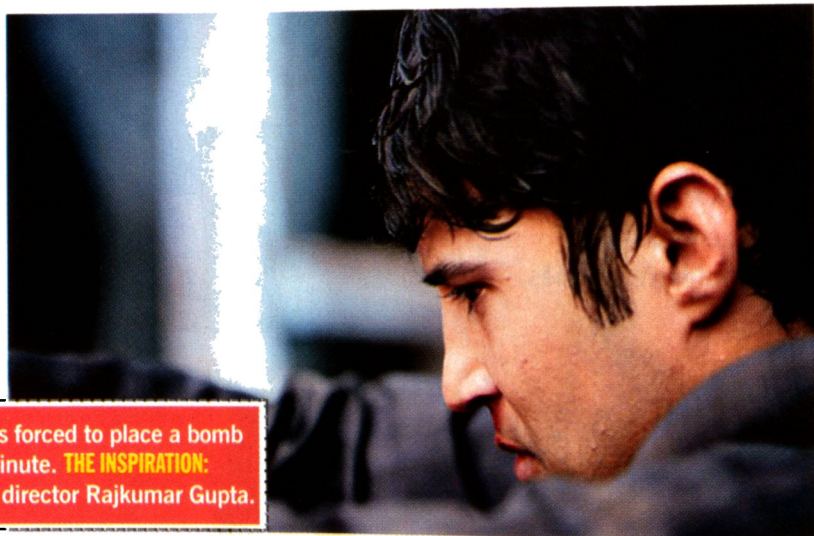
CONTRACT

RGV's analysis of Mumbai underworld, circa 2008, when shootouts are down, but the nexus with terrorism is up. **THE INSPIRATION:** Actual events in Mumbai.

we were taught in socialist India. It's an India which has the means but no meaning in life." For Shibani Bhatija, who's written *My Name is Khan* and Sanjay Gadhvi's *Kidnap*, where a headstrong young man abducts the girl he loves and clashes with her father, real life is messier, with no set beginning, middle and end, and more often than not, no answers to dilemmas. "Both these films are not true stories, but they address contemporary issues. The former takes on a moral issue and the latter a social issue. Hopefully, both will feel real."

For the producers, marketing such films is both easy and difficult. The

it," he says. For Bhandarkar, the film took two years of his life, one spent doing the research and another shooting it—a cumbersome task involving the staging of at least eight fashion shows, complete with a smartly turned out crowd comprising foreigners hired from the beaches of Goa and walk-ins by Karan Johar and Manish Malhotra. These movies are making Hindi film actors out of unlikely people. In *Mission Istanbul*, Lakhia, who had spent eight



AAMIR

A London-returned doctor is forced to place a bomb on a bus, but backs off at the last minute. **THE INSPIRATION:** "The times we live in," says newbie director Rajkumar Gupta.

months researching his earlier film, *Shootout in Lokhandwala*, based on a 1991 gunbattle between gangsters and the Mumbai police, bullied his junior from Lawrence School, Sanawar, Omar Abdullah into making an appearance as himself while in Rajkumar Gupta's *Aamir*, former MTV head Shashanka Ghosh plays a Muslim *bhai*.

For Varma, the starting point for *Contract* was the fact that though there were 108 shootouts in Mumbai in 1998, there were just five in 2006. "Mumbai's underworld has become a conduit for the terrorist network," says the director, whose meanderings into Mumbai's dark side have been much cloned. It's a theme Kunal Deshmukh too touched upon in *Jannat* when he showed the

nexus between match fixing and terrorism in the Dawood Ibrahim-like figure of Abu Ibrahim, played by Pakistani actor Javed Sheikh.

What's behind this dalliance with the dark side, seen even in Subhash Ghai's uneven *Black and White* and soon to be seen in Karan Johar's *My Name is Khan*, where Shah Rukh Khan plays a Muslim facing life in a post-9/11 New York? A bit of fear, for sure. As Shivdasani puts it: "If the new directors don't do something new, who will? The audiences will just reject us." It's also the urge to connect with a discerning audience. As Mahesh Bhatt says, "In *Jannat*, there's this mall brat who works in a call centre and the risk addict who stands against everything

movies have no stars so they don't sell themselves, which is why the marketing budgets are almost equal to the production budget (*Aamir* cost UTV Spotboy Rs 2 crore to make, and Rs 2 crore to sell). Yet, the underdog movies can spark discussions and debates, become part of water cooler conversations and drawing room chats.

But will this walking on the edge last? How many times will films open on shots of morning walkers, suburban trains, and steaming glasses of *garam chai*? Will the stories being told by Kamat and company be at once complex and compelling? It may well be because as Bhatt points out, "The best illusions are manufactured with one's feet on the ground."